comprised an expanse of cultivated plains. The monotony of these plains was broken by the dramatic Barabar alignment of granite, rising ‘like rocks from the sea’.[2] Today, the Siddeshwarnath temple crowns one of the peaks. From here the hilly contours, rock exposures, water reservoirs, and the Phalgu river in the distance form a stunningly beautiful landscape, enough to evoke some envy for the ascetics who made this hill their abode in the third century BCE. Ascetics of the Ajivika order had, as we saw, prophesied glad tidings for Ashoka, so a disinterested distribution of caves to sundry sects may not have been the idyllic scenario painted sometimes by those desiring to boost the emperor’s proto-secular credentials. This was all the same a major philanthropic act, the first instance of caves created on this scale in this part of the world, and very likely to have been widely recognized in Ashoka’s own time.

There are four such caves. Three are located in a prominent whale-shaped natural outcrop,[3] the Lomasha Rishi cave and the Sudama cave being adjacent to each other. When these names came to be attached to the caves is unknown, they did not exist in Mauryan times. The Sudama cave was called ‘Nigoha Kubha’ or Banyan cave,[4] and is referred to thus in Ashoka’s short donative epigraph there. The recessed entrance of the Sudama cave bears a dedicatory inscription by ‘Priyadarshin’ dating to when he had been anointed twelve years. A great deal of effort went into the creation of this cave. It comprises two chambers, both of which were highly polished, a rectangular outer one with a vaulted roof and an inner chamber with a hemispherical ceiling circular in plan and imitating a thatched hut. Like the Sudama cave, the adjacent Lomasha Rishi cave was two-chambered. What made it different was a carved architrave above the entrance on its exterior. In this, the central arch shows a row of elephants in motion, moving towards a central stupa from both sides. Immediately above this, in the middle arch, a kind of lattice screen is made up of an intersecting circle design—the type that is carved on the throne (‘vajrasana’) that